

Good vs. Leading Questions

A quick reference for Session 4 and for your own discovery conversations.

The move: from *leading* to *learning*

Leading questions invite a polite "yes" or a made-up answer. Good questions ask about **real, past behavior**.

INSTEAD OF (LEADING)	ASK (LEARNING)
"Would you use an app that does X?"	→ "Tell me about the last time you dealt with [problem]."
"Do you think this is a good idea?"	→ "How do you handle this today?"
"Wouldn't it be great if...?"	→ "What's the most frustrating part of...?"
"Do you usually...?"	→ "Walk me through the last time you did..."
"How much would you pay for this?"	→ "What do you currently spend (time or money) on this?"
"Does this problem bother you?"	→ "When did this last cost you time or money?"
"You'd want feature Y, right?"	→ "What have you tried to solve this? What happened?"

Four follow-up moves

- **"Walk me through the last time..."** — anchors to a real instance instead of a generality.
- **"Why?" / "What happened next?"** — dig past the first, surface-level answer.
- **"How do you deal with it now?"** — surfaces workarounds (proof the problem is real).
- **Silence** — let them fill it. Don't rush to talk.

Don't

- Pitch your idea, then ask what they think.
- Treat compliments as data.
- Ask about the future ("would you...") — ask about the past.
- Do most of the talking.

Consent & ethics (course norms)

You're talking to real people — treat it with care. This is **course-level needfinding**, not **formal human-subjects research** (no IRB needed), but the norms still apply:

- **Ask permission and say why.** *"I'm a student learning about [problem] — could I ask you a few questions? About 10 minutes."*
- **Be honest.** You're there to learn, not to sell. Don't pretend to be doing something you're not.
- **No recording without explicit permission.** Notes are fine; ask first for audio/video.
- **Respect their time and their "no."** They can stop, skip a question, or decline.
- **Protect their privacy.** Don't put names or identifying details in your notes or brief without consent — summarize and anonymize.
- **Check with the instructor first** before interviewing sensitive populations or topics (minors, health information, anything you're unsure about).

Go deeper: *The Mom Test* — *Key Ideas* · *Interview Ethics for Students* · *Interview Prompt Cards* (all on Canvas → Course Resources).